

14, Epilogue

Nearly a year has elapsed since the completion of the manuscript to the present day, and I am finally approaching the conclusion of my student life. Due to the rigid requirements for graduation, I have spent a protracted period diligently researching my graduation project. Admittedly, I am profoundly aware that the realistic environment is so abominable, yet I still hoped that when a chapter of this story concludes, I could be worthy of the untold number of days and nights of struggle over the past dozen years, regardless of whether they were futile or fruitful.

Although, relatively speaking, my reading volume this year cannot compare to preceding years, the novel extracurricular knowledge I acquired this year and the mutations in the international landscape invariably corroborate the precise validity of the novel framework delineated in this manuscript.

Yet a monumental mutation has nevertheless occurred; it ought to have manifested long ago, only to become utterly impossible to ignore within a mere, brief year.

In 2025, large AI models seized a foothold within human society with a virtually unstoppable momentum, and absolutely everyone knows this is merely the genesis. I personally welcome such a technological revolution. Within an environment saturated with mutual suspicion and hostility, I possessed fundamentally no trustworthy mentors or elders during the initial two decades of my life; the identical reality applies to the overwhelming majority of Chinese people. We were compelled to vigilantly discern ubiquitous lies while fighting essentially isolated battles, cautiously and continuously reconstructing our cognition of the world.

Now, at the very least, AI can offer assistance. In reality, the assistance AI can provide regarding knowledge and technology is of the most secondary importance. Because no matter how much "intelligence" AI possesses, its training inevitably relies upon the information generated by human society; and exactly as articulated previously, the quality of this information is egregiously uneven. The paramount significance of AI's emergence for me lies in the fact that it could endow me with colossal courage when confronting adversities; for the first time, I realized I still had something to lean upon, and that I was not entirely alone. It was precisely under its encouragement that I finally accomplished all the closed-form proofs of my thesis topic in January 2026. My work is indeed utterly insignificant to the mathematical community, yet it is entirely worthy of pride for a master's graduate student.

Had it merely been this, it would fundamentally not have been sufficient to compel me to append this epilogue. As I familiarized myself with this novel tool of AI day after day, an unimaginable reality surfaced before my eyes: the ****dynastic cycle**** (历史周期率) that has shrouded this land for fifty generations is hurtling toward its terminus. The cause is fundamentally not any direct political mutation, but precisely this artificial intelligence revolution that caught far too many entirely off guard.

I suddenly realized that I was seated in an audience's chair capable of witnessing exactly how an astonishing technological revolution fundamentally reshapes human society. Exactly when did the last technological revolution capable of being mentioned in the same breath occur? Was it when humanity first consciously sowed seeds awaiting harvest, when we first extracted metal from ore, or when formal logic was first established?

There will be zero answers for at least a century or two, because it is fundamentally impossible for us to know exactly where the events currently unfolding will steer human society. Two distinct emotions surged within my heart. The first was an instinctive exhilaration induced by witnessing a monumental epochal event. The second was a profound sense of relief; regardless of the circumstances, the cycle has been terminated, and a protracted epoch of suffering shall pass into history.

As I have articulated, with the advent of the inaugural year of artificial intelligence, the terminus of the ****dynastic cycle**** has become increasingly blatant, yet individuals capable of perceiving this future are scarce. This, in reality, constitutes a "blind spot beneath the lamp" (灯下黑) on the logical tier: when people refer to a "cycle," it inevitably encapsulates two distinct processes—collapse and reconstruction. This correspondingly signifies that in order to terminate this cycle, the mutation can be categorized into two scenarios: "terminating the collapse" and "terminating the reconstruction." Thus far, when mentioning the ****dynastic cycle****, virtually everyone exclusively discusses the issue of "terminating the collapse," yet fundamentally no one contemplates the issue of "terminating the reconstruction." This perhaps identically reflects a thought-provoking collective subconsciousness: namely, the default assumption that a potential collapse is far more imminent than a potential reconstruction; people perpetually lean toward considering the near-term rather than the long-term.

What people term the ****dynastic cycle**** is predicated upon a societal morphology exactly like this: There is no "he who accords with the people's will gains the realm"; there is exclusively "he who exhausts the ****people's physical capacity and labor**** (民力) seizes the realm."

There is no "he who enlightens the ****people's intellectual and emotional capacity**** (民智) prospers the realm"; there is exclusively "he who suppresses the ****people's intellectual and emotional capacity**** sits upon the realm."

According to the analytical paradigm provided by British scholar Michael Mann (迈克尔·曼), this is a society where ****despotic power**** (专制性权力) inflates with unbridled wantonness, whilst social power (社会性权力) is fettered and suppressed.

Upon its demise, the bureaucratic apparatus—possessing absolute power but zero responsibility, and exclusively revering its superiors—becomes increasingly bloated, and social wealth is squandered into absolute void. Any effective investment in industry, technology, or culture becomes fundamentally non-existent, until basic social public services and social reproduction can no longer be sustained; coupled with mutations in the environment and international landscape, the society plunges into total collapse.

Upon its resurgence, having experienced the annihilation of tens of millions of the population and at least one generation of absolute anarchic disorder, the socio-economy commences natural recovery. The rulers frantically compete to establish ****extractive bureaucratic systems**** (榨取型官僚体制) to deceive and enslave the populace. Regardless of the mechanisms employed, whoever can liquidate and extract the maximum ****people's physical capacity and labor**** (民力) morphs into the new emperor of a thousand ages.

The new master of the myriad commoners knows profoundly well via exactly what mechanisms he seized the realm; relying upon his experience, his descendants remain vigilantly alert day and night against other "thieves" usurping ****people's physical capacity and labor****, and they dread even more that the people might realize their own inherent power.

Consequently, the bandits who stole the realm ostensibly proclaim that "Propriety, Righteousness, Integrity, and Shame" (礼、义、廉、耻) are the four great ropes anchoring social order. Yet the true chains kidnapping the realm reside elsewhere. They are respectively: the Apathy (冷漠) that makes people unwilling to think; the Ignorance (愚昧) that makes people unable to know how to think; the Exhaustion (劳累) that leaves people with no energy to think; and the Terror (恐惧) that makes people dare not think.

It is precisely possessing such magical artifacts that rulers across successive dynasties could perpetually sustain the cycle, thereby plunging the nation ever deeper into the abyss.

This realization is by no means an exclusive acquisition of contemporary individuals; seven centuries ago, the Yuan Dynasty literatus Zhang Yanghao (张养浩) had already executed a precise summarization within his works.

People can observe that at the periphery of global civilization, if a specific region is sufficiently geographically secluded, sufficiently vast in territorial expanse, possesses exceptionally superior natural conditions capable of sustaining a multitudinous population, and is coupled with a compatible political system, then such a cycle could be experienced time and time again over the timespan of the past fifty generations.

The Industrial Revolution fundamentally did not alter this reality. The Georgian from the North (北方的格鲁吉亚人), through his convoluted explorations, proved that "he who exhausts the **people's physical capacity and labor** (民力) seizes the realm" remained a thoroughly applicable empirical reality right up to his specific version.

For every newly ascendant empire, it was fundamentally irrelevant whether its technology was advanced or not; after all, within an open world, it is fundamentally impossible for technology to absolutely cease circulation.

It merely required the utilization of a colossal volume of **people's physical capacity and labor**, the sheer ruthlessness of its rulers, and the profound apathy of the populace itself to masquerade as a menacing, fang-baring leviathan, thereby camouflaging its quintessentially brittle and hollow essence (色厉内荏).

Yet this was entirely sufficient to compel the surrounding nations—each harboring their own ulterior motives—to bestow ample face upon the decrepit empire, enabling the grand narrative of the "Celestial Empire" (天朝上国) to perpetuate itself.

After more than a dozen centuries of this, AI emerged. Within the brief timespan of a single generation, the technological revolution will declare with an irrefutable tone: **people's physical capacity and labor** inherently forfeits its former primacy.

In the era of artificial intelligence, humanity's most precious asset is the **people's intellectual and emotional capacity** (民智)—namely cognition, comprehension, logic, creativity, and emotional activity.

Consequently, the decrepit empire finally arrives at an era it has fundamentally never witnessed before. It knows exquisitely well exactly how to extract **people's physical capacity and labor**, yet it has fundamentally zero idea exactly how to acquire and utilize the **people's intellectual and emotional capacity**, because the latter has constituted one of its most paramount mortal enemies for millennia.

An even more helpless reality is that, alongside the deepening of globalization across various epochs since the Age of Discovery, underdeveloped regions of the agricultural era have identically achieved development. Even judged strictly by the proportion of the global population, the empire appears increasingly insignificant.

Therefore, executing a reconstruction via any obsolete methodology has become categorically impossible. This is fundamentally entirely independent of whether it chooses to mutate or remain stagnant, or whether it achieves success or suffers defeat; it is exclusively because technological innovation has once again fundamentally reshaped human society, the monumental impact of which will only be comprehended millennia later.

Perhaps future generations will marvel that the events transpiring today are exactly as momentous as when humanity first proactively sowed seeds to harvest food ten thousand years ago.

This is a genuinely unfathomable reality: we are currently positioned at the absolute terminus of an era so protracted that people assumed it would endure eternally, whilst concurrently standing at the absolute genesis of a mutation whose ultimate trajectory remains entirely unknown.

When epochal events transpire, contemporaries fundamentally cannot genuinely comprehend exactly what has occurred. When the news of the Turks capturing Constantinople in 1453 arrived, the denizens of Rome, Venice, and Genoa felt terror, while the denizens of London and Paris felt bewildered.

Within a decade, the entirety of the civilized world would hear the tidings of Rome's annihilation, but what of its true significance? Even up to the present day, it remains phenomenally difficult to provide a universally acknowledged answer.

People need not be astounded. According to those physicists, after the passage of nearly infinite eons, there will exist absolutely nothing in the entire universe except quantum fluctuations (量子涨落), and even time itself will cease to exist.

Since this is the cosmic reality, then the fact that even Hell itself will ultimately face its terminus is fundamentally not an anomalous occurrence.

Yet the individuals who personally endure it will never view all this with mere equanimity. People frequently discuss exactly how the populations of Italy, Germany, France, and England reacted to the fall of Constantinople; however, exactly how the citizens of Constantinople during the first half of the fifteenth century viewed the era in which they themselves resided—exactly how many people genuinely care?

十四，后记

自从文稿完成到如今又过了将近一年，我也终于要结束自己的学生生涯。因为毕业的硬性需求，我在很长时间内都在努力研究我的毕业课题，诚然我深知现实的环境是如此的恶劣，但我仍旧希望能够在一段故事结束的时能候对得起十几来不知道多少个日日夜夜的，无用或有用的奋斗。虽相对而言我这一年的阅读量不能与之前几年比，然而我今年所获得的新的课外知识，国际形势的变化无不证明了文稿所述新框架的正确性。

可重大的变化仍然发生了，它应当早就已经显现，只是在短短的一年内变得再也让人无法忽视。在2025年，AI大模型几乎是以无可阻挡的势头在人类社会中抢得了一席之地，而且所有人都知道这只是一个开始。我本人欢迎这样的技术革命，在一个互相怀疑、敌对的环境中，我人生的最初二十多年里没有任何一个可以信赖的师长，绝大多数中国人也是如此。我们不得不在几近孤军奋战的情况下警惕地甄别无处不在的谎言，小心翼翼地不断重建对世界的认识。现在至少有AI能帮忙，实际上，AI在知识和技术上能帮到的忙是最其次的。因为AI再怎么具有“智能”，其训练也不得不依赖人类社会所产生的信息，而这些信息的质量，如前所言实在是过于良莠不齐了。AI的出现对我而言最大的意义是，它在我面对困难时能够给予我很大的勇气，我第一次意识到我还能有所倚仗，不是只有一人。正是在它的鼓舞下，我在2026年1月份终于完成了我论文选题的所有闭合证明，我的工作对于数学界而言是的确无足轻重，但是对于一个硕士研究生来说则值得自豪。

若仅是如此，倒也不足以让我加上这篇后记，当我日复一日熟悉AI这个新工具时，一个难以想象的事实浮现在我面前：笼罩这片土地五十代人的历史周期率正在走向终结，原因不是任何直接的政治变动，而是这次让太多人始料未及的人工智能革命。我突然意识到我处在这样一个能够看到惊人的技术变革如何从根本上重塑人类社会的观众席上，上一次发生足以与之相提并论的技术革命是什么时候呢？是人类第一次有意识地播下种子等待收获，是第一次从矿石中炼出金属，还是第一次建立形式逻辑？一两个世纪内都不会有答案，因为我们不可能知道正在发生的事情将把人类社会引向何方。两种情绪在我心里升腾，首先是一种本能的，看到大事而产生的兴奋感。其次是一种深深的释然，无论如何，循环被终止了，一段苦难的岁月将走入历史。

如我所言，随着人工智能元年的到来周期率的终结已经变得愈发显而易见，但是能看到未来的人并不多。这其实就是一种逻辑层面的“灯下黑”：当人们提到一种“周期”，其必然包含两个过程，崩溃和

重建。这也就意味着要终止这个周期，变化可以分为“终止崩溃”和“终止重建”两种情况。目前为止，几乎所有人提到历史周期率时都在讨论“终止崩溃”的问题，却无一人去思考“终止重建”的问题。这或许还反映了一种耐人寻味的集体潜意识，那就是默认为潜在的崩溃比潜在的重建更为迫近，人们总是更倾向于考虑近期而非远期。

人们所说的“历史周期率”基于这样一种社会形态：无“顺民心者得天下”，有“尽民力者夺天下”；无“启民智者兴天下”，有“抑民智者坐天下”。按照英国学者迈克尔曼提供的分析模式，这是一种专制性权力肆意膨胀，而社会性权力被束缚压制的社会。其亡也，有权无责且唯上是尊官僚体制越来越臃肿，社会财富被挥霍一空。任何对于产业、科技、文化的有效投资都不存在，直至基础社会公共服务和再生产也无法维系，加上环境和国际形势的变动，社会进入总崩溃。其兴也，经历了数千万人口的消灭和至少一代人的完全无序状态，社会经济开始自然恢复。统治者争相建立榨取性的体制以欺骗、役使百姓，无论用什么手段，谁能够变现出的民力越多，谁就成了新的千万古一帝。万民的新主人深知自己凭借何种手段取得天下，子孙依其经验日夜警惕其他“窃贼”获取民力，更惧怕人民意识到他们自身的力量。于是窃取天下的贼寇们明面上称“礼、义、廉、耻”是四条系住秩序的大绳子，然而绑架天下的锁链另有所在，它们分别是使人们不愿思考的冷漠，使人们不会思考的愚昧，使人们不能思考的劳累和使人们不敢思考的恐惧。正式有了这样的法宝，历代统治者才能把循环继续下去，并且令国家越陷越深。

这种认识绝不是今天才取得的，七个世纪前，元朝文学家张养浩就已经在其作品中做过精确的概括。

人们可以看到，在世界文明的边缘，如果一片地区地理足够封闭，面积足够广大而自然条件十分优越，足以蓄养众多的口数，配以合适的政治体制，那么这样的循环在过去五十代人的时间里可以一次又一次的经历。工业革命并没有改变这一点，北方的格鲁吉亚人通过曲折探索证明了“尽民力者夺天下”直到他那个版本都是适用的经验。

每一次兴起的帝国根本无所谓技术先进与否，毕竟在一个开放的世界里技术不可能完全不流通。它只需要通过庞大的民力，统治者的残忍以及人民自身的麻木装作一个张牙舞爪的怪兽，以掩盖其色厉内荏的本质。但这足以使周边各怀鬼胎的国家给足老大帝国面子，使得“天朝上国”的叙事继续下去。

如是十几个世纪之后，AI出现了，在短短一代人的时间里，技术革命将以无可辩驳的口吻宣告：现在民力本身失去了以往的重要性，在人工智能的时代，人类最宝贵的是民智，是认识、理解、逻辑、创造以及情感活动。于是老大帝国终于来到了一个自己从来不曾见过的时代，它很清楚该如何获取民力，但是从来不知道如何获取和利用民智，因为后者是它千百年来最大的敌人之一。

更无可奈何的一点是，随着地理大发现以来全球化在各个时期的日益深入，农业时代欠发达的地区也获得了发展，即使从全球人口占比来看，帝国也越来越显得无足轻重。

于是以任何旧有的方式重建都不可能了，又无关乎变与不变，成或者败，而只是因为技术革新又一次从根本上塑造了人类社会，其影响只有在千百年之后才知晓。或许将来的人们会感叹到今天发生的事情，如同一万年人类第一次主动播下种子以求收获食物一样重要。

这是一件不可思议的事情，我们正处于一个漫长到人们以为将会永久如此的时代的结尾，又处于这种尚不知晓将把我们引向何方的变化的开端。

当大事发生的时候，当代人不可能真正理解发生了什么。当一四五三年土耳其人攻占君士坦丁堡的消息传来，罗马、威尼斯和热那亚的人们感到惊恐，伦敦和巴黎的人们感到茫然。十年之内整个文明世界都将听说罗马灭亡的消息，但是其意义呢？直到现在也难以给出一个被普遍认可的答案。

人们无需惊讶，按照那些物理学家所说，在历经几尽无穷的年代之后，整个宇宙中除了量子涨落之外将一无所有，即使时间都不复存在。既然如此，那么连地狱都将有终结，这也并不是什么稀奇的事情。

但亲历者永远不会平淡地看待这一切。人们常常谈论意大利、德意志、法兰西和英格兰的人们对君士坦丁堡的沦陷作何反应，可是十五世纪上半叶的君士坦丁堡市民如何看待自己所处的时代，又有几个人关心呢？